SMB AI Readiness Playbook

A Practical Guide for Business Owners Ready to Stop Guessing and Start Growing

By Ignition Agency | ignitionagency.au **Version 1.0** | 2025 Edition

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This playbook is for the business owner who keeps hearing about AI, maybe tried a few tools, and still isn't sure whether their business is ready — or what "ready" even looks like. By the time you finish this guide, you'll know exactly where you stand, what's holding you back, and what to do next.

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SECTION 1

Why Most AI Implementations Fail (and How to Be Different)

Let's start with an uncomfortable truth.

Most small and medium businesses that "try AI" fail at it — not because AI doesn't work, but because they go about it backwards.

They see a LinkedIn post about ChatGPT. They watch a YouTube video about automating their inbox. They sign up for three tools in a week, spend a weekend tinkering, get underwhelming results, and conclude that "AI isn't really for businesses like mine."

That's the wrong conclusion to draw. The right conclusion is: **AI requires a foundation.**

You wouldn't hire three new staff members before you had proper job descriptions, onboarding processes, and systems to manage them. AI is no different. If your business processes are fuzzy, your data is scattered, and your team doesn't know why change is happening — the smartest AI tool in the world will give you chaos at speed.

This playbook exists to fix that.

The Real Reason AI Fails in Small Business

Here's what the research actually shows — and what we see firsthand working with SMBs across Australia:

Reason #1: Businesses try to automate the wrong things first.

Most people start with whatever is top of mind — usually something frustrating but not actually high-value. They automate answering emails but haven't fixed the fact that half those emails exist because their FAQ page is outdated. You can't automate your way out of a process problem.

Reason #2: Data is a mess.

AI tools are only as smart as the data you feed them. If your customer records live in three different spreadsheets, your CRM is half-updated, and your invoicing system doesn't talk to anything else — you're building on sand. AI will produce inconsistent, unreliable results and your team will lose faith in it fast.

Reason #3: The team wasn't brought along.

Imagine being a receptionist who suddenly has an AI tool handling the first response to every enquiry — without anyone explaining why, or asking for your input. Resistance and quiet sabotage are almost guaranteed. People fear being replaced, and when leadership doesn't communicate clearly, fear wins.

Reason #4: Expectations are completely wrong.

AI is not magic. It does not "just figure it out." It does not replace the need for human judgement in most cases. Business owners who expect a $99/month tool to replace a full-time employee and triple their revenue in 90 days will be disappointed every time.

Reason #5: There's no one driving it.

Every successful AI implementation we've seen has had a champion — one person whose job it is to shepherd the change, troubleshoot, gather feedback, and keep momentum going. Businesses that treat AI as a "set it and forget it" tool stall out within weeks.

The Businesses That Get It Right

The businesses that succeed with AI share a few things in common:

- They **start with a clear problem to solve**, not a tool to try
- They **prepare their data and processes** before switching anything on
- They **communicate openly** with their team about what's changing and why
- They **set realistic 90-day goals** and measure against them

- They **get help when they need it** rather than burning months figuring it out alone

This playbook will walk you through all of it.

By the end, you'll have:

- A clear picture of your AI readiness today (Section 2 & 3)
- A personalised 90-day roadmap based on your score (Section 6)
- Specific tool recommendations within your budget (Section 7)
- A library of prompts you can use immediately (Section 9)

Let's start with the most important step: finding out where you actually are.

> 💡 **Quick Note on Language** Throughout this playbook, "AI" refers broadly to artificial intelligence tools — including large language models like ChatGPT and Claude, automation platforms like Zapier and Make, and purpose-built business AI tools. We won't assume you know any of this already. Everything is explained as we go.

SECTION 2

The AI Readiness Score

Your 20-Question Self-Assessment

This self-assessment will give you a clear, honest picture of where your business stands across five dimensions that matter most for AI success. Take your time. Answer honestly — this is for your benefit, not anyone else's.

How it works: - 20 questions across 5 dimensions (4 questions each) - Each answer is worth 0, 1, or 2 points - Maximum possible score: 40 points - Your total score places you in one of four readiness levels

Grab a pen and paper, or a notes app. Write down your answer score for each question as you go.

Dimension 1: Data Quality

How clean, organised, and accessible is your business data?

Question 1: Where does your customer data live?

- **(0)** It's spread across emails, spreadsheets, sticky notes, and memory. There's no single source of truth.
- **(1)** We have a CRM or database, but it's partially filled in and not regularly maintained.

- **(2)** We have a CRM or central system that's reasonably complete, regularly updated, and used by the team.

Score: ____

Question 2: How consistent is your data entry across the business?

- **(0)** Everyone does it differently. Some people fill things in, others don't bother. There's no standard.
- **(1)** We have some guidelines but they're not enforced. Data quality varies a lot depending on who entered it.
- **(2)** We have clear standards for how data is entered, and most of the team follows them consistently.

Score: ____

Question 3: Could you pull a reliable customer list with contact details, purchase history, and last contact date in under 10 minutes?

- **(0)** No. It would take significant time and effort, and the result still wouldn't be fully reliable.
- **(1)** Probably, but it would need cleaning and cross-referencing with a few different sources.
- **(2)** Yes — we could do this quickly and trust the output.

Score: ____

Question 4: How long do you retain and organise historical business data (sales, customer interactions, financial records)?

- **(0)** We don't really have a retention policy. Old data is either lost or buried somewhere inaccessible.
- **(1)** We keep data, but it's not well organised or easily searchable. It would take a while to find anything specific.

- **(2)** We keep at least 12 months of clean historical data that's accessible and reasonably easy to query.

Score: ____

Dimension 1 Total: ____ / 8

Dimension 2: Process Documentation

How well-defined and documented are your core business processes?

Question 5: How are your core business processes documented?

- **(0)** They live in people's heads. Nothing is written down in any formal way.
- **(1)** Some key processes are documented, but it's patchy — maybe a few SOPs or a rough onboarding doc.
- **(2)** Most core processes are documented clearly enough that a new employee could follow them without constant handholding.

Score: ____

Question 6: When a key staff member is away, what happens to their work?

- **(0)** Things fall through the cracks or someone else scrambles to figure out what to do.
- **(1)** There's some handover, but it's not smooth. Things slow down noticeably.
- **(2)** We have clear coverage processes. Work continues with minimal disruption.

Score: ____

Question 7: How well can you describe the exact steps in your most common customer journey — from first contact to delivery to follow-up?

- **(0)** I could give you a rough idea, but I'd struggle to list the exact steps in order.

- **(1)** I know the main steps, but there are gaps, exceptions, and informal workarounds I'd have to explain verbally.
- **(2)** I could map it out clearly, step by step, including who does what and what tools are used at each stage.

Score: ____

Question 8: How often do you review and update your business processes?

- **(0)** Rarely or never. We do what works until it stops working.
- **(1)** Occasionally — maybe when something breaks or we bring someone new on board.
- **(2)** Regularly — we treat our processes as living documents and update them as the business evolves.

Score: ____

Dimension 2 Total: ____ / 8

Dimension 3: Team Readiness

How prepared is your team for AI-driven change?

Question 9: How would you describe your team's general attitude toward new technology?

- **(0)** Resistant. New tools usually face pushback, slow adoption, or quiet non-compliance.
- **(1)** Mixed. Some people are enthusiastic, others cautious or indifferent. Adoption is uneven.
- **(2)** Generally open. The team adapts to new tools reasonably well when there's a clear reason for the change.

Score: ____

Question 10: Has anyone in your business had meaningful experience using AI tools (ChatGPT, Copilot, automation tools, etc.)?

- **(0)** Not really. Maybe someone's used ChatGPT casually but there's no real AI experience in the team.
- **(1)** A few people have dabbled, but it hasn't been used in any structured or business-relevant way.
- **(2)** Yes — at least one person has used AI tools in a business context and understands how to get useful results from them.

Score: ____

Question 11: How does your business typically handle significant operational change?

- **(0)** Poorly. Change initiatives tend to stall, get half-implemented, or quietly die after a few weeks.
- **(1)** It depends on the change. Some stick, some don't. We don't have a strong change management process.
- **(2)** Reasonably well. We communicate clearly, give people time to adapt, and follow through on implementation.

Score: ____

Question 12: Do you have someone in the business who could champion an AI initiative — drive it, troubleshoot it, and keep the momentum going?

- **(0)** No. It would have to be me (the owner), and I'm already stretched thin.
- **(1)** Maybe. There's someone who might be able to take it on, but it's not their current role and capacity is uncertain.
- **(2)** Yes. I have at least one person who is technically capable, process-minded, and has bandwidth to lead this.

Score: ____

Dimension 3 Total: ____ / 8

Dimension 4: Tech Stack Compatibility

How well does your current technology support AI integration?

Question 13: How would you describe your current software stack?

- **(0)** A mix of outdated, disconnected, or mostly manual tools. Lots of spreadsheets and workarounds.
- **(1)** A mix of decent tools, but they don't talk to each other well. Some integration, but not much.
- **(2)** Reasonably modern cloud-based tools that are either already integrated or easily could be.

Score: ____

Question 14: Do your core business tools (CRM, accounting, project management, communication) have API access or integration capabilities (e.g., they work with Zapier, Make, or similar)?

- **(0)** I honestly don't know, or I know they don't.
- **(1)** Some of them do, but I haven't explored this much.
- **(2)** Yes — I know my key tools support integration and I've either used this already or understand how it works.

Score: ____

Question 15: How secure and private is your business data management?

- **(0)** We don't have formal data security policies. Data handling is ad hoc.

- **(1)** We take basic precautions (passwords, some access control) but haven't formalised anything.
- **(2)** We have clear policies around data access, storage, and handling. We're reasonably confident our data is secure.

Score: ____

Question 16: How comfortable are you migrating or upgrading software tools when needed?

- **(0)** It's painful and disruptive. We tend to stick with what we have even when it's not working well.
- **(1)** We can do it, but it takes significant time and causes disruption. We try to avoid it when possible.
- **(2)** It's manageable. We've done it before, and we have a reasonable approach to transitions.

Score: ____

Dimension 4 Total: ____ / 8

Dimension 5: Budget & Timeline Realism

Are your expectations and resources aligned with reality?

Question 17: What is your realistic monthly budget for AI tools and implementation?

- **(0)** Zero, or close to it. We'd need to see results before committing any spend.
- **(1)** A small but meaningful amount — somewhere between $100 and $500 per month, with willingness to invest more if results are proven.
- **(2)** $500 or more per month, and I understand this is an investment that may take 3–6 months to show strong ROI.

Score: ____

Question 18: How much time can you or your team realistically dedicate to AI implementation and learning over the next 90 days?

- **(0)** Minimal — maybe a few hours total. Everyone is at capacity.
- **(1)** A few hours per week across the team. Not a lot, but something.
- **(2)** Meaningful time — at least 2–4 hours per week for one dedicated person, with some additional team time for training.

Score: ____

Question 19: What does success with AI look like to you in 12 months?

- **(0)** I'm not sure. I just know I need to do something with AI or get left behind.
- **(1)** I have a general sense — something like "save time" or "handle more customers" — but no specific targets.
- **(2)** I have a specific goal or two in mind with a rough idea of what measurable improvement would look like.

Score: ____

Question 20: How does your business leadership (you and any partners or senior staff) feel about taking an experimental approach — trying things, measuring, adjusting — rather than expecting a perfect result first time?

- **(0)** Uncomfortable. We prefer to know something will work before we invest time and money in it.
- **(1)** Somewhat open to it, but we'd need to see early wins to maintain confidence and keep going.
- **(2)** Comfortable. We understand that iteration is how you find what works, and we're willing to learn from failures.

Score: ____

Dimension 5 Total: ____ / 8

Your Score Summary

Fill in your totals below:

DIMENSION	YOUR SCORE	MAX SCORE
1. Data Quality		8
2. Process Documentation		8
3. Team Readiness		8
4. Tech Stack Compatibility		8
5. Budget & Timeline Realism		8
TOTAL		**40**

Your AI Readiness Score: ____ / 40

Now turn the page to find out what it means.

SECTION 3

Scoring Your Results

What Your Score Actually Means

Before we dive into the four readiness levels, a few important notes:

This score is a starting point, not a verdict.

A low score doesn't mean AI isn't for your business — it means you have preparation work to do first, and that's completely normal. Most SMBs sit in the lower ranges when they first do this assessment. The businesses that end up succeeding with AI are the ones that do the groundwork rather than skip it.

Pay attention to your lowest dimension, not just your total.

A business might score 36/40 overall but have only 2/8 in Data Quality. That single weak area can derail even the best-laid AI plans. Your lowest-scoring dimension is your highest-priority focus area.

Your score will change.

Within 90 days of focused preparation work, most businesses can move up by at least one readiness level. This is a dynamic assessment, not a fixed label.

Score Ranges at a Glance

SCORE	READINESS LEVEL	WHAT IT MEANS
0 – 12	**Unplugged**	Foundation work needed before any AI investment
13 – 22	**Wired**	Ready to explore, but key gaps need addressing first
23 – 32	**Connected**	Good foundation — time to implement strategically
33 – 40	**Ignited**	Ready to scale and optimise with advanced AI

Understanding Your Dimension Scores

Beyond your total, look at each dimension individually. Here's what low scores in each area mean — and what you should do about them.

Low Score in Data Quality (0–3/8)

This is the most common bottleneck and the most important one to fix. Without clean, organised data, AI tools will give you inconsistent and unreliable results. Before doing anything else, invest time in getting your data in order.

Immediate priorities: - Identify your single most important data source (customer records, sales data, etc.) - Set a standard for how data gets entered and by whom - Dedicate time each week to cleaning and consolidating existing records

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Low Score in Process Documentation (0–3/8)

You can’t automate a process you haven’t defined. If your processes live in people’s heads, AI will entrench that chaos, not fix it. Map your top 3 workflows before implementing any AI.

Immediate priorities: - Pick your single most repeated business workflow - Map it out step by step — even a simple flowchart or numbered list is a start - Identify where the decisions are made and by whom

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Low Score in Team Readiness (0–3/8)

Technology is a people problem as much as a technical one. A resistant team will sabotage even excellent tools. Before introducing AI, spend time on communication, involvement, and building internal capability.

Immediate priorities: - Have an honest conversation with your team about why AI matters and what it means for them - Identify your most enthusiastic team member as your internal AI champion - Start small with a low-stakes tool that makes someone’s day genuinely easier

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Low Score in Tech Stack Compatibility (0–3/8)

Older or disconnected tools create friction that limits what AI can do. This doesn’t mean you need to overhaul everything at once, but you need a plan for modernising your stack.

Immediate priorities: - Audit your current tools against cloud-based alternatives - Check whether your key tools (especially CRM and communication) support API or Zapier integration - Identify the single biggest integration gap and address it first

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Low Score in Budget & Timeline Realism (0–3/8)

This one is about mindset as much as money. Unrealistic expectations are the fastest way to give up too early. AI implementation is an investment — in time, money, and patience.

Immediate priorities: - Set a realistic 12-month budget for tools + implementation - Write down one specific goal AI should help you achieve in the next 90 days - Accept that the first attempt at something rarely works perfectly — that’s part of the process

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SECTION 4

The 4 AI Readiness Levels

Where You Fit Right Now

Each of the four readiness levels has its own characteristics, challenges, and recommended path forward. Find your level and read it carefully — the rest of this playbook builds on it.

Level 1: Unplugged (Score 0–12)

Who you are:

You're running a real business — probably successfully — but largely on intuition, manual processes, and personal relationships. Your systems are informal, your data is scattered, and tech tools have been adopted reactively rather than strategically.

You might feel some anxiety about AI. It sounds like a lot of work, a lot of expense, and you're not sure what you'd actually do with it. You might have tried a tool or two and found it overwhelming or underwhelming.

The honest truth:

Right now, introducing AI to your business would be like installing a high-performance engine in a car with no steering wheel. The power would be wasted — or worse, create new problems.

That doesn't mean AI isn't for you. It means you have foundational work to do first — and here's the silver lining: **that foundational work has enormous value**

regardless of AI. Getting your processes documented, your data organised, and your team aligned will make your business run better with or without AI tools.

Your primary focus for the next 90 days:

Foundation building, not tool adoption. Specifically: - Organise your most important data into one place - Document your top 3 business processes - Have honest conversations with your team about technology - Pick one small, low-risk AI tool to experiment with — not to deploy widely, but to start building familiarity

What AI looks like for you right now:

Start with tools that require no integration with your existing systems. ChatGPT or Claude for writing and thinking tasks. That's it. Nothing that requires clean data or complex setup.

Level 2: Wired (Score 13–22)

Who you are:

You've got more in place than you might think. You're running on real systems — probably a CRM of some kind, some documented processes, a team that's reasonably capable. But there are meaningful gaps. Data quality is inconsistent. Some processes are in people's heads. Your tech tools don't talk to each other much.

You've probably tried a few AI tools, maybe with mixed results. You're curious but cautious.

The honest truth:

You're closer than you think, but the gaps you have are the ones that will trip you up if you rush. The most common mistake at this level is picking a sophisticated AI tool before plugging the holes in your foundation.

A few weeks of targeted preparation — clean up one data source, document two or three key workflows, get your team aligned — can move you to Level 3 faster than you expect.

Your primary focus for the next 90 days:

Gap-closing, then careful tool selection. Specifically: - Identify your two biggest weak spots from the assessment and address them directly - Pick one high-value, well-defined business process to automate or assist with AI - Build your team's confidence with one simple, visible AI win before going broader

What AI looks like for you right now:

Content creation assistance (blog posts, proposals, email templates), meeting summaries, basic chatbot for customer enquiries, simple automation of repetitive admin tasks. Start with one of these, do it well, then expand.

Level 3: Connected (Score 23–32)

Who you are:

You have a solid foundation. Your data is reasonably clean. Your processes are documented, at least for the important stuff. Your team can handle change. Your tech stack is mostly cloud-based and at least partially integrated.

You might already be using some AI tools — maybe ChatGPT for writing, or Zapier for some automations. You're ready to get more systematic and strategic about it.

The honest truth:

This is where the real gains start. You have enough of a foundation to implement AI in ways that will make a measurable difference to your business — not just productivity experiments, but genuine revenue and time impact.

The risk at this level is doing too many things at once. The businesses that get the best results focus relentlessly on one or two use cases, nail them, measure the results, and then expand. Resist the temptation to implement everything on your wish list simultaneously.

Your primary focus for the next 90 days:

Strategic implementation. Specifically: - Choose your highest-impact AI use case (customer service, sales, content, operations — pick one) - Implement it properly: clean data input, clear process, team training, measurement framework - Document your results so you can replicate the approach for the next use case

What AI looks like for you right now:

CRM-integrated AI for sales follow-up, AI-assisted customer service (chatbot or AI triage), automated reporting and analytics, AI-generated content at scale, workflow automation across multiple tools. This is where it starts getting genuinely powerful.

Level 4: Ignited (Score 33–40)

Who you are:

You're ahead of most SMBs in Australia. Your systems are clean, your team is capable, your stack is modern, and you understand that AI is an iterative investment, not a one-time fix. You may already have significant AI integration in parts of your business.

The honest truth:

You're in a position most businesses would envy. But staying at this level requires continuous investment — in learning, in tooling, in your team's capabilities. AI is evolving fast, and the tools that are cutting-edge today will be table stakes in 18 months.

The businesses at this level that fall behind are the ones that get complacent. They implemented AI in 2023, it worked, and they stopped paying attention. Meanwhile, competitors who started later caught up because they kept iterating.

Your primary focus for the next 90 days:

Scaling and optimising. Specifically: - Audit your existing AI implementations for ROI and identify what to double down on - Explore more advanced use cases: predictive analytics, AI agents, custom model fine-tuning - Build internal AI capability — training, documentation, experimentation culture - Consider where AI can give you a genuine competitive advantage in your market

What AI looks like for you right now:

AI agents, custom integrations, predictive analytics, automated customer journeys, AI-assisted hiring and HR, advanced content personalisation, competitive intelligence tools. The full toolkit is available to you.

SECTION 5

The Most Common Mistakes SMBs Make with AI

(And Exactly How to Avoid Them)

These aren't theoretical mistakes. They're patterns we see repeatedly in businesses across industries and sizes. Every one of these can derail an otherwise promising AI initiative. Learn from others so you don't have to learn the hard way.

Mistake #1: Starting with the Tool, Not the Problem

What it looks like: "I heard about this AI tool that does X. Let's implement it."

The business signs up, spends two weeks configuring it, and then realises they're not quite sure what problem it's solving — or that the problem it solves isn't actually costing them much.

Why it happens: AI tools are exciting and the marketing is compelling. It's easy to reverse-engineer a justification after you've already decided you want the thing.

The fix: Always start with the problem statement, not the tool. Write it down: "We are losing X hours per week on Y task, which costs us approximately $Z per month." Then find the tool that solves that specific problem. You'll be far more deliberate about your selection, and far less likely to waste money on something that looks impressive but doesn't actually help.

Mistake #2: Implementing AI Before Fixing Broken Processes

What it looks like: A business automates its customer onboarding workflow. The automation works — but the onboarding process itself was confusing and incomplete. Now it's automated confusion.

Why it happens: There's a tempting assumption that AI will fix process problems. It won't. AI executes processes faster and more consistently — which is great when the process is good, and terrible when it isn't.

The fix: Before you automate anything, walk through the process manually. Map every step. Identify the pain points, the bottlenecks, the places where things fall through the cracks. Fix those problems first — with your own brain, some conversations, and perhaps a whiteboard. Then automate the clean process.

> **Rule of thumb:** Never automate a process you haven't already simplified.

Mistake #3: Ignoring Data Quality

What it looks like: A business implements an AI tool to personalise customer communications. The AI starts sending emails to "Dear [FIRST NAME]" because half the customer records don't have first names, or they're entered as "SMITH, JOHN" rather than "John."

Why it happens: Data quality is invisible until it becomes embarrassing. Most businesses don't realise how messy their data is until they try to use it for something systematic.

The fix: Before any AI implementation that relies on your existing data, do a data quality audit. Pick a random sample of 50 records from whatever data source you're using. How many are complete? How many are correctly formatted? How many are duplicates? That sample will tell you a lot about the state of your data overall — and whether it needs work before you proceed.

Mistake #4: Not Getting Buy-In from the Team

What it looks like: The business owner comes back from a conference, excited about AI. They implement a new tool within a week. Staff feel blindsided, worried about their jobs, and passively resistant. Six months later, the tool is technically "live" but barely used.

Why it happens: Leaders often underestimate how much their team's adoption matters. A 10/10 AI tool used by a resistant team will produce worse results than a 7/10 tool used by an engaged one.

The fix: Include your team from the start. Ask them where they spend the most time on repetitive tasks. Ask what frustrates them most about current processes. Frame AI as something that will handle the boring, repetitive stuff so they can focus on the work that actually requires human intelligence and judgement. Most people come around quickly when they understand that AI is there to remove the drudgery, not their jobs.

Mistake #5: Treating AI as "Set and Forget"

What it looks like: A business implements a chatbot. It works reasonably well for the first month. Over time, it starts giving outdated information, failing to handle new enquiry types, and frustrating customers. Nobody has updated it because everyone assumed it was running itself.

Why it happens: AI tools feel like software — and we're used to software that just runs without much maintenance. But AI tools that interact with customers or make decisions need regular review and updating. Your business changes. Your customers' questions change. The AI needs to keep up.

The fix: Every AI implementation needs an owner — a human who is responsible for reviewing performance, updating inputs, and making adjustments. Schedule a monthly check-in for each AI tool you deploy. Treat it like a team member who needs occasional feedback and direction, not a machine that looks after itself.

Mistake #6: Trying to Do Everything at Once

What it looks like: Excited by the possibilities, a business implements a new CRM with AI features, an AI chatbot, an email automation tool, a content generation tool, and a reporting dashboard — all in the same quarter.

Six weeks later, nothing is working well, the team is overwhelmed, and the owner doesn't know where to look to understand why.

Why it happens: The AI landscape is genuinely exciting, and there's a lot of FOMO (fear of missing out). Every tool looks like it could solve a real problem. Saying no feels like leaving money on the table.

The fix: Pick one use case, implement it properly, measure the results, and then move to the next. The depth of your implementation matters more than the breadth of your tool stack. One well-configured AI tool that your team actually uses is worth ten half-implemented ones that nobody trusts.

Mistake #7: Underestimating the Time Required

What it looks like: A business owner allocates "a few hours on the weekend" to get an AI tool up and running. The tool is live by Monday, but setup is incomplete, the team hasn't been trained, and the outputs are mediocre. The owner concludes the tool isn't worth it.

Why it happens: Tool vendors make onboarding look effortless in their demos. The reality of configuring a tool for your specific business, training your team, and refining the outputs is significantly more time-intensive than the demo suggests.

The fix: For any meaningful AI implementation, budget 2–4 weeks of part-time effort for initial setup, testing, and team training. Then budget ongoing time for monthly reviews and updates. If that feels like too much, it's a signal to either simplify the scope or get external help to accelerate it.

Mistake #8: Not Measuring Anything

What it looks like: A business implements AI for content creation. The owner has a vague sense that it's saving time. Twelve months later, when someone asks

whether the AI investment was worth it, there's no answer — because nothing was measured.

Why it happens: Measurement feels like extra work, especially when you're already busy. It's easy to skip in the implementation rush.

The fix: Before you implement any AI tool, write down your baseline. How long does the task currently take? How much does it cost? How often does it happen? Then measure the same metrics three months after implementation. You need to know whether it's working, how well it's working, and whether you're getting value for money.

> **A simple template:** Before AI: [task] takes [X hours] per week, done by [person], at a cost of approximately $[Y] per month. After 90 days: [new measurements].

Mistake #9: Ignoring Data Privacy and Security

What it looks like: A business starts feeding customer data — names, emails, purchase history, sometimes sensitive financial information — into an AI tool without reading the terms of service or understanding how that data is stored and used.

Why it happens: Privacy considerations often feel like a legal abstraction. When a tool is giving you useful results, it's easy to overlook the fine print about data handling.

The fix: Before putting any customer data into an AI tool, read the privacy policy and data handling section. Key questions: Where is the data stored? Is it used to train the AI? Who has access to it? Is it compliant with Australian Privacy Act requirements? If you're unsure, run it past a legal adviser or use only aggregated, anonymised data in public AI tools.

Mistake #10: Expecting AI to Replace Human Judgement

What it looks like: A business uses AI to screen job applications. The AI filters candidates based on keyword matching. Several excellent candidates who don't fit the keyword profile are eliminated. The business ends up hiring someone mediocre because they gamed the keywords.

Why it happens: There's a natural tendency, once you have a capable AI tool, to trust it more than you should. This is especially true for decisions that are time-consuming and where human judgement feels subjective.

The fix: Use AI to assist human decision-making, not replace it — especially for decisions that significantly affect people (hiring, customer service escalations, financial recommendations). Treat AI outputs as a first draft or a first filter, not a final answer. Keep humans in the loop wherever the stakes are high.

SECTION 6

Your 90-Day AI Readiness Roadmap

Personalised by Readiness Level

The following roadmaps are practical, week-by-week guides tailored to your starting point. Find your level from Section 3 and follow the corresponding plan.

Each roadmap is structured in three 30-day phases: - **Month 1: Foundation** — Getting your house in order - **Month 2: Experiment** — Low-risk first implementations - **Month 3: Measure & Expand** — Review, refine, and move forward

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Roadmap A: Unplugged (Score 0–12)

You're building from the ground up. Don't rush. The work you do in these 90 days will pay dividends for years, regardless of what AI tools you eventually adopt.

Month 1: Foundation

Week 1–2: Data Triage

Your first priority is getting visibility over your most important data.

- Identify your single most important data category (usually: customer contact records or sales history)

- Do a manual audit: pull every source of that data you can find (spreadsheets, email, notebook, your head)
- Consolidate it into one place — a spreadsheet is fine for now
- Remove duplicates, fill in obvious gaps, standardise the format

Goal: By end of week 2, you have a single, reasonably clean list of your top 50–100 customers or recent transactions.

Week 3–4: Process Mapping

Pick the one business process that happens most often and has the most steps — usually: customer enquiry → quote → onboarding → delivery → follow-up.

- Sit down with anyone involved in that process
- Map every step in order, starting from the customer's first contact
- Note who does each step, what tool they use (if any), and roughly how long it takes
- Identify the top 3 pain points (where things go wrong or slow down)

Goal: A one-page process map, even if it's rough. This document is gold.

Month 2: Experiment

Week 5–6: Team Conversation

Don't introduce any tools yet. Have a proper conversation first.

- Schedule 30 minutes with your team (or key staff)
- Explain what you're working on: "I want to make our business more efficient, and I'm exploring some tools that might help us with [specific task]"
- Ask: "What takes the most time in your week that feels repetitive?" — take notes
- Explicitly address the jobs question: "This is about removing the tedious stuff, not replacing people"

Goal: Understand your team's perspective. Identify one task they'd love to see automated.

Week 7–8: First AI Experiment

Choose one of the following low-risk, high-value starting points:

- **Option A:** Use ChatGPT or Claude to draft email templates for your 3 most common customer communications (follow-up after enquiry, proposal cover note, project completion email)
- **Option B:** Use an AI transcription tool (Otter.ai or similar) to record and transcribe your next three client meetings
- **Option C:** Use ChatGPT to create a simple FAQ document from your most common customer questions

Do this personally first. Learn the tool before handing it to your team.

Goal: One completed AI experiment that produced something genuinely useful.

Month 3: Measure & Expand

Week 9–10: Evaluate and Document

- Compare the quality and time cost of your AI experiment vs the old way
- Write a one-paragraph summary: what worked, what didn't, what you'd do differently
- Share the result with your team — good or bad, transparency builds trust

Week 11–12: Plan Your Next 90 Days

- Re-take the readiness assessment. Has your score improved?
- Identify your two biggest remaining gaps
- Based on what you've learned, set a concrete goal for the next 90 days
- Consider whether you need external help to move faster (see Section 8)

Goal: A written plan for your next 90 days, informed by real experience.

Roadmap B: Wired (Score 13–22)

You have a workable foundation. Your focus is on closing the most important gaps and implementing one high-value AI use case properly.

Month 1: Foundation

Week 1–2: Targeted Gap Assessment

Based on your dimension scores, identify your two lowest areas and focus there first.

- **Data Quality gap:** Pick your primary data source (usually CRM or customer database) and run a 50-record audit. Note the error rate and common problems. Fix them. Establish a data entry standard in writing.
- **Process Documentation gap:** Choose your most important client-facing process. Map it end to end in a Google Doc or Notion page. Share it with everyone involved for review.
- **Team Readiness gap:** Hold a 45-minute team meeting. Bring three examples of AI helping similar businesses. Ask for their biggest frustrations with current processes.
- **Tech Stack gap:** Audit your current tools. Note which ones are cloud-based. Check whether each integrates with Zapier (zapier.com/apps). Identify any critical tool that has no integration options.

Goal: Two specific gap areas addressed with a concrete artefact (a cleaned data set, a documented process, a meeting summary, a tool audit).

Week 3–4: Define Your First Use Case

Choose one and only one use case for your first AI implementation. Criteria for a good first use case: - High frequency (happens multiple times per week) - Significant time cost (at least 2–3 hours per week across the team) - Relatively predictable inputs and outputs (not heavily dependent on complex judgement calls) - Low risk if it goes slightly wrong (not customer-facing on day one if you can help it)

Examples by business type:

BUSINESS TYPE	STRONG FIRST USE CASE
Professional services	Client proposal drafting
Retail	Product description writing
Trade / services	Job scheduling and dispatch communications
Healthcare / allied health	Patient communications and appointment reminders
Hospitality	Menu copy, booking responses
Consulting / coaching	Content creation and follow-up emails

Goal: One clearly defined use case written down: the problem, the current process, the expected AI-assisted process, and how you'll measure success.

Month 2: Experiment

Week 5–6: Tool Selection and Setup

For your chosen use case, research 2–3 tools that address it specifically. Prioritise tools that: - Offer a free trial - Have good documentation and support - Integrate with tools you already use - Have a clear privacy policy

Set up your chosen tool with proper configuration. Don't rush this. Read the documentation. Watch setup videos. Most tools have a 1–3 hour setup time for proper configuration.

Week 7–8: Controlled Rollout

- Start with yourself or one team member — not the whole team
- Run the AI-assisted process in parallel with the old process for two weeks
- Keep a simple log: date, task, time taken with AI, quality rating (1–5)
- Identify what needs tweaking (prompts, settings, data inputs)

Goal: Two weeks of parallel testing data. Enough to know if the tool is worth expanding.

Month 3: Measure & Expand

Week 9–10: Review and Decide

- Analyse your parallel testing data
- Calculate time saved, quality comparison, and team sentiment
- Make a go/no-go decision on expanding to the full team
- If yes: create a simple training document (1 page, not a manual)

Week 11–12: Team Rollout and Next Use Case

- Train your team on the new tool (30-minute session is usually enough)
- Assign an “AI champion” who owns ongoing performance and maintenance
- Begin planning your second use case — now you know what a successful implementation looks like

Goal: One AI tool properly deployed, measured, and owned. One new use case planned.

Roadmap C: Connected (Score 23–32)

You’re ready for real impact. Your focus is on strategic, high-value implementation with proper measurement and team capability building.

Month 1: Foundation

Week 1–2: Strategic AI Audit

Before adding new tools, audit what you already have.

- List every software tool currently in your stack
- For each tool: does it have an AI feature you’re not using? Check the settings and release notes.
- Identify your top 3 highest-cost, most time-consuming processes
- Prioritise them by: (time cost × frequency) ÷ implementation complexity

Goal: A prioritised list of AI opportunities, starting with quick wins.

Week 3–4: Data Architecture Review

At this level, data quality issues will limit your ceiling. Take one week to review: - Are your key tools syncing data reliably? (CRM ⊡ accounting ⊡ communications) - Are there data silos that are limiting your visibility? - Do you have a dashboard or reporting tool that gives you a regular business overview?

If not: set up a simple reporting dashboard (many CRMs have this built in, or use Google Looker Studio for free).

Month 2: Experiment

Week 5–8: Flagship Implementation

Choose your highest-impact use case and implement it properly. At this level, aim for something that will deliver measurable time or revenue impact:

- **Customer service:** AI chatbot handling first-line enquiries (reduces staff time, improves response time)
- **Sales:** AI-assisted CRM follow-up sequences (ensures no lead falls through the cracks)
- **Content:** Systematic AI content production (blog posts, social media, email newsletter)
- **Operations:** Automated reporting and exception alerts (saves hours of manual report compilation)

For your chosen use case: 1. Map the current process end to end 2. Identify which steps AI can handle and which require human input 3. Design the new workflow with AI integrated at the right points 4. Build and test before going live 5. Set up measurement from day one

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Month 3: Measure & Expand

Week 9–10: Measurement and Optimisation

- Compare baseline vs current performance on your target metric

- Identify what's working and what isn't — be specific
- Optimise the 20% of things causing 80% of problems
- Document the process so it can be replicated for the next use case

Week 11–12: Team Capability and Scaling Plan

- Run an internal training session: 2–3 hours, focused on practical AI skills your team can use right now
- Create an internal "AI playbook" (a simple shared doc) with the tools you use, how to use them, and prompts that work
- Build a 6-month AI roadmap: which use cases are next, what investment is required, what results you're targeting

Goal: One flagship AI implementation delivering measurable results. Team trained and capable. Clear six-month plan in place.

Roadmap D: Ignited (Score 33–40)

You're in a strong position. Your focus is on scaling, optimising, and building sustainable competitive advantage.

Month 1: Audit and Prioritise

Week 1–2: Comprehensive AI ROI Audit

For every AI tool and implementation currently in use: - What metric was it meant to improve? - What has it actually improved? - What's the monthly cost? - Is it earning its seat at the table?

Retire anything that isn't delivering measurable value. Consolidate where you're paying for overlapping capabilities.

Week 3–4: Competitive and Market Intelligence

- Research what AI adoption looks like in your specific industry
- Identify 2–3 capabilities that aren't yet standard in your market but are becoming so

- These are your differentiation opportunities — be early, not late

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Month 2: Advanced Implementation

Week 5–8: Next-Level Use Case

At this level, you're ready for more sophisticated implementations:

- **AI agents:** Tools that can take multi-step actions on your behalf (research, draft, send, follow up) with defined parameters and guardrails
- **Custom integrations:** Purpose-built connections between your tools and AI capabilities, tailored to your exact workflow
- **Predictive analytics:** Using your historical data to forecast demand, identify at-risk customers, or flag operational bottlenecks before they become problems
- **Personalisation at scale:** AI-driven customer communication that adapts to individual behaviour and preferences

Choose one. Plan it properly. Build it with a clear brief, defined success metrics, and a review date.

Month 3: Scale and Systematise

Week 9–12: Build Your AI Operating System

At this level, you're not just using AI tools — you're building a systematic approach to AI in your business:

- **AI policy document:** How your business uses AI, what data can go into public tools, and what requires internal-only handling
- **Continuous learning practice:** One AI-focused learning activity per month for you and your team (newsletter, webinar, course, experiment)
- **Innovation pipeline:** A running list of AI use cases to explore, with a regular (quarterly) review to decide what moves to implementation
- **External expertise relationship:** A consultant, agency, or advisor who keeps you current on what's changing and helps you avoid expensive mistakes

Goal: AI embedded as a genuine business system, not a collection of point tools. Clear governance, measurement, and continuous improvement.

SECTION 7

Tool Stack Recommendations by Budget

$0 / $500/mo / $2K/mo

The right tools depend on your budget, your use cases, and your technical capacity. These are our recommended starting stacks based on the businesses we work with. Every tool listed has been selected for practical value, ease of use, and suitability for SMBs.

Note: Prices are approximate as of 2025 and subject to change. Always check current pricing on the provider's website.

Budget Tier 1: $0/month (Completely Free)

Who this is for: Businesses just getting started with AI, or those who want to build confidence before committing any spend.

TOOL	WHAT IT DOES	BEST FOR
ChatGPT (Free)	General-purpose AI assistant	Writing, research, brainstorming, drafting emails
Claude (Free)	Alternative AI assistant with strong reasoning	Long documents, complex analysis, nuanced writing
Google Gemini (Free)	AI assistant integrated with Google Workspace	Gmail drafting, Google Docs assistance, search-integrated research
Otter.ai (Free tier)	Meeting transcription and notes	Recording and summarising meetings and calls
Canva (Free)	AI-assisted design	Social media graphics, presentations, basic marketing materials
Notion AI (trial)	AI-assisted notes and documentation	Process documentation, meeting notes, knowledge base
Google Looker Studio	Reporting and dashboards	Basic business reporting from Google Sheets, Analytics, etc.

How to use this stack: - Use ChatGPT or Claude daily for writing assistance — emails, proposals, social posts, FAQs - Use Otter.ai for any client or team meetings to get automatic transcripts - Use Canva for any visual content needs — the free tier is genuinely powerful - Build simple dashboards in Looker Studio to get visibility over your key metrics

Realistic outcome: 3–5 hours per week saved on writing and communication tasks. Measurably better quality of written outputs. A growing sense of what AI can and can’t do in your specific context.

Budget Tier 2: ~$500/month

Who this is for: Businesses ready to invest in proper tools that integrate with their existing stack and deliver meaningful time savings.

Sample monthly breakdown:

TOOL	PURPOSE	APPROX. COST/MO
ChatGPT Plus or Claude Pro	Advanced AI for the whole team	$30–60
Zapier (Starter)	Automation between your tools	$30–80
HubSpot CRM (Starter)	CRM with AI features for sales follow-up	$50–100
Notion AI	Team knowledge base and documentation	$15–30
Otter.ai (Business)	Meeting transcription for the team	$30
Jasper or Copy.ai	Structured content production	$50–80
Buffer or Publer	AI-assisted social media scheduling	$20–40
Loom	Screen recording for async team communication	$15
Contingency / extras	New tools, trials, add-ons	$100–150
Total		**~$340–565**

How to use this stack: - HubSpot + Zapier creates a basic automated sales pipeline: leads captured → CRM → automated follow-up sequence → deal tracking - ChatGPT/Claude Pro for the whole team means consistent, higher-quality outputs at scale - Jasper or Copy.ai for systematised content production: blog posts, email

sequences, product descriptions - Buffer for scheduling all social posts in advance — keep the queue filled weekly rather than posting manually each day

Realistic outcome: 8–12 hours per week saved across the team. A functioning automated sales follow-up process. Consistent content output without proportional time investment.

Budget Tier 3: ~$2,000/month

Who this is for: Established businesses ready to use AI as a genuine competitive advantage — automating complex workflows, integrating deeply with their stack, and building scalable customer experiences.

Sample monthly breakdown:

TOOL	PURPOSE	APPROX. COST/MO
ChatGPT Team or Claude Team	AI for all staff with privacy controls	$100–200
Make (formerly Integromat) Pro	Advanced automation and multi-step workflows	$100–200
HubSpot Professional	Full CRM, marketing automation, AI insights	$400–900
Intercom or Freshdesk	AI-powered customer service chatbot	$100–300
Jasper Business	Enterprise content at scale	$150–200
Databox or Klipfolio	Advanced business intelligence dashboards	$100–200
Fireflies.ai	AI meeting intelligence and CRM integration	$30–80
Grammarly Business	Writing quality for all team communications	$50–100
Custom AI solutions / retainer	Specialist help, custom integrations	$200–500
Total		**~$1,230–2,680**

How to use this stack: - HubSpot Professional enables full marketing automation: lead scoring, behaviour-triggered email sequences, sales pipeline AI - Intercom or Freshdesk handles first-line customer support automatically — common questions answered 24/7, complex issues routed to humans - Make (Pro) enables sophisticated multi-tool automations: new customer → CRM + accounting + project management + welcome email, all triggered automatically - Databox/Klipfolio gives you real-time business intelligence — revenue, customer acquisition, team productivity — in one dashboard - The retainer line is important: at this investment level, having experienced help to configure and maintain your stack properly pays for itself

Realistic outcome: 20+ hours per week saved across the team. Automated customer acquisition and nurture sequences. Measurably faster and more consistent customer service. Real-time business visibility. A genuine operational edge over less systematised competitors.

> ⚠️ **Important Note on Tool Stacks** The specific tools listed above are current as of 2025 and represent a sensible starting point, not a definitive prescription. The right stack for your business depends on your industry, your existing tools, and your specific use cases. Before committing to any significant monthly spend, run a trial. Most of these tools offer 14–30 day free trials. Use them.

SECTION 8

When to DIY vs When to Get Help

This is one of the most practical questions in AI implementation, and the honest answer isn't the same for every business.

Here's a framework for making the call.

The DIY vs Get Help Decision Matrix

FACTOR	DIY	GET HELP
Complexity	Simple, single-tool setup	Multi-tool integration or custom development
Time	Plenty of available time	Time-poor, need results quickly
Technical skill	Comfortable with software setup	Mostly non-technical team
Stakes	Low-risk internal tools	Customer-facing or revenue-critical systems
Budget	Tight — need to minimise spend	Budget available, prioritising speed and quality
Learning value	Want to build internal capability	Want the result, not the learning curve

Strong Cases for DIY

You should do it yourself when:

1. You're experimenting with writing tools. ChatGPT, Claude, and similar text-based AI tools are built for non-technical users. Anyone comfortable with email can learn to use them effectively. The learning curve is minimal and the upside of building your own prompting skills is significant.

2. You're setting up simple automations between popular tools. Zapier's interface is designed for non-developers. Connecting two mainstream tools (like "when I get a new form submission, add it to my CRM") is something most business owners can handle with an afternoon of learning.

3. The use case is internal and low-stakes. If you're experimenting with AI for internal processes — meeting notes, internal drafts, team communication — the risk of getting it wrong is low. Use these low-stakes scenarios to build your confidence and skills.

4. You have time and a technical team member. If you have someone who is technically capable, curious, and has the bandwidth to learn, investing in their skills is often better long-term than outsourcing. They'll become your internal AI champion.

Strong Cases for Getting Help

You should get external help when:

1. Customer-facing systems are involved. If AI is going to interact with your customers — chatbot, automated email responses, personalised recommendations — get it right the first time. A bad customer experience is worse than no AI experience. Experienced help significantly reduces the risk of embarrassing or frustrating outcomes.

2. You need multiple tools to work together seamlessly. Once you're connecting three or more tools in a meaningful workflow — CRM, accounting, project management, communication, and an AI layer across all of them — the complexity increases significantly. Mistakes at the integration level are hard to diagnose and can cause data quality issues that are expensive to unpick.

3. You're making significant monthly commitments. If you're evaluating tools at the $500–2,000+/month level, the cost of getting the selection and setup wrong is substantial. A few hours with an experienced consultant can save months of wasted spend.

4. You've tried DIY and it's not working. There's no shame in trying something yourself and then getting help when you hit a wall. What you've learned from your DIY attempt will make you a much better client — you'll know what the problems are, what you've already tried, and what you're actually trying to achieve.

5. Your time is worth a lot. If you're billing at $200/hour, spending 20 hours learning a tool that a specialist could configure in 4 hours is a $4,000 opportunity cost. At a certain hourly rate, getting help is just arithmetic.

Finding the Right Help

Not all AI consultants or agencies are equal. When you're looking for help, here's what to look for:

They start with your problem, not their favourite tool. A good consultant asks about your business first — your processes, your goals, your challenges. A bad one starts by telling you about the tool they know best.

They can explain things in plain language. If you're confused by what they're proposing, that's a red flag. Good implementation partners can explain exactly what they're building, why, and how you'll know it's working.

They have SMB-specific experience. Enterprise AI implementations and SMB implementations are very different. Make sure the person you're working with understands the constraints — budget, time, team capacity — that SMBs operate under.

They measure outcomes, not activities. Your engagement should have clear success criteria. Not "we'll implement X tool" — that's an activity. "We'll reduce customer response time by 60% and save your team 5 hours per week" — that's an outcome. Get the latter in writing.

They train your team. Any implementation that leaves you dependent on the consultant for ongoing maintenance is a bad implementation. Good partners build your team's capability alongside the solution.

> 💡 **The Ignition Agency Approach** This is exactly how we work. We start with your business problem, not our favourite tools. We build solutions your team can understand and own. And we measure everything. If you want to explore whether we're the right fit, there's a free 30-minute audit available at ignitionagency.au — details at the end of this playbook.

SECTION 9

Bonus: AI Prompt Library

10 Ready-to-Use Prompts with Examples

This section gives you 10 prompts you can use immediately in ChatGPT or Claude (or any similar AI tool). These are not generic prompts — they're written for SMB business contexts and include worked examples so you can see what kind of output to expect.

Copy them, adapt them to your business, and start using them today.

How to Use These Prompts

1. Open ChatGPT (chat.openai.com) or Claude (claude.ai)
2. Copy the prompt
3. Replace the [BRACKETS] with your specific information
4. Paste and send
5. Review, refine, and iterate — rarely is the first output perfect, but it's almost always a strong starting point

---

Prompt 1: Customer Enquiry Response

Use case: Responding to a common customer question professionally and thoroughly.

The Prompt:

```
You are a friendly, professional customer service representative for [BUSINESS
NAME],
a [BUSINESS TYPE] based in [LOCATION].

A customer has sent the following enquiry:
"[PASTE CUSTOMER ENQUIRY HERE]"

Write a response that:
- Addresses their question directly and completely
- Is warm but professional in tone
- Includes a clear next step for the customer
- Is between 100-150 words
- Does not use jargon or overly formal language

Our key services include: [LIST YOUR MAIN SERVICES]
Our standard turnaround time is: [YOUR TURNAROUND TIME]
```

Example Output (for a bookkeeping firm):

“Hi Sarah — great question. Our standard bookkeeping packages include monthly reconciliation, BAS preparation, and a quarterly review call with your bookkeeper.

For a business your size (5–10 staff), our most popular package is our ‘Growth’ tier at $450/month. This covers everything you’d need on an ongoing basis, and there are no setup fees.

I’d love to hop on a quick 20-minute call to understand your current setup and make sure we’re recommending the right fit for you. You can book directly here: [LINK], or just reply to this email with a couple of times that work.

Looking forward to connecting!“

Prompt 2: Proposal Cover Letter

Use case: Writing the opening page of a quote or proposal.

The Prompt:

```
Write a professional but warm proposal cover letter for a quote I'm sending
to
[CLIENT NAME], who runs [BRIEF DESCRIPTION OF THEIR BUSINESS].

They came to us with the following problem or need:
[DESCRIBE WHAT THEY NEED IN 2-3 SENTENCES]

Our proposed solution is:
[BRIEF DESCRIPTION OF WHAT YOU'RE PROPOSING]

Key benefits we're offering:
[LIST 3-4 MAIN BENEFITS]

The tone should be confident, consultative, and personal — not salesy.
Australian English. Maximum 200 words.
```

Prompt 3: Job Ad

Use case: Writing a job advertisement that attracts the right candidates.

The Prompt:

```
Write a job advertisement for the following role at our company.

Company: [COMPANY NAME]
Business type: [WHAT YOU DO]
Location: [LOCATION] (and whether remote/hybrid/in-office)
Role title: [JOB TITLE]
Employment type: [Full-time / Part-time / Casual / Contract]

Key responsibilities:
[LIST 4-6 MAIN RESPONSIBILITIES]

What we're looking for:
[LIST SKILLS, EXPERIENCE, AND PERSONALITY TRAITS]

What we offer:
[SALARY RANGE, PERKS, CULTURE HIGHLIGHTS]

Write a job ad that sounds human and genuine, not like a corporate HR
```

```
template.
It should attract people who are the right fit — not just qualified on paper.
Australian English. Around 300 words.
```

Prompt 4: Social Media Post Series

Use case: Creating a week's worth of social media content quickly.

The Prompt:

```
Create 5 social media posts for [PLATFORM — e.g., LinkedIn / Instagram /
Facebook]
for my business, [BUSINESS NAME].

We are a [BUSINESS TYPE] that helps [TARGET CUSTOMER] achieve [MAIN OUTCOME].

Here are 5 topics or ideas I want to cover this week:
1. [TOPIC 1]
2. [TOPIC 2]
3. [TOPIC 3]
4. [TOPIC 4]
5. [TOPIC 5]

For each post:
- Write the full post text (appropriate length for [PLATFORM])
- Include a relevant question or call to action at the end
- Use a natural, conversational tone — not corporate or overly promotional
- Use Australian English
- Do NOT use excessive hashtags (maximum 3 per post)
```

Prompt 5: Meeting Agenda

Use case: Preparing a structured, purposeful agenda before a client or team meeting.

The Prompt:

```
I have a [LENGTH] meeting coming up with [WHO — e.g., "a potential new
client",
"my management team", "a supplier"].

Purpose of the meeting: [WHAT YOU'RE TRYING TO ACHIEVE]

Background context:
[2-3 SENTENCES ABOUT THE SITUATION OR RELATIONSHIP]

Key topics I need to cover:
[LIST 3-6 TOPICS]

Create a structured meeting agenda that:
- Opens with a clear purpose statement
- Allocates time to each agenda item
- Includes space for questions and next steps
- Ends with a clear summary of actions and owners
```

Prompt 6: Email Newsletter

Use case: Writing a monthly or fortnightly email newsletter to your customer list.

The Prompt:

```
Write an email newsletter for [BUSINESS NAME]'s subscriber list.

Our business: [BRIEF DESCRIPTION OF WHAT YOU DO AND WHO YOU SERVE]

This edition's main topic: [MAIN TOPIC OR STORY]

Additional items to include:
- [ITEM 2, e.g. "A tip or piece of useful advice for our audience"]
- [ITEM 3, e.g. "A recent project or case study we're proud of"]
- [ITEM 4, e.g. "A promotion or offer running this month"]

Tone: Warm, helpful, and human. Like a trusted expert writing to a friend,
not a marketing department writing to a database.

Length: Approximately 400 words.
```

```
Subject line: Provide 3 options.
Australian English.
```

Prompt 7: Difficult Customer Response

Use case: Responding to a complaint or difficult customer situation professionally.

The Prompt:

```
A customer has sent the following complaint or difficult message:
"[PASTE THEIR MESSAGE]"

The situation from our perspective is:
[EXPLAIN WHAT HAPPENED AND ANY RELEVANT CONTEXT — BE HONEST]

Our preferred resolution is:
[WHAT YOU'RE ABLE OR WILLING TO OFFER]

Write a professional, empathetic response that:
- Acknowledges their experience without being defensive
- Takes appropriate responsibility (without admitting liability where not
warranted)
- Offers the resolution clearly
- Maintains the relationship wherever possible
- Is calm, measured, and human in tone
- Australian English. Maximum 200 words.
```

Prompt 8: Process Documentation

Use case: Turning a messy, verbal process into a clear written SOP.

The Prompt:

```
I'm going to describe a business process to you in rough, informal terms.
Your job is to turn it into a clear, professional Standard Operating
Procedure
(SOP) that a new employee could follow.
```

```
Here is my rough description of the process:
[DESCRIBE THE PROCESS AS IF EXPLAINING IT TO SOMEONE VERBALLY —
don't worry about structure or completeness, just brain-dump it]

Please produce an SOP that includes:
- Process name and purpose
- Who is responsible for each step
- Step-by-step instructions in numbered format
- Any tools, templates, or systems used at each step
- Decision points (if X, then Y)
- Common mistakes to avoid
- A "how to know you've done it right" checklist at the end
```

Prompt 9: Competitive Positioning Statement

Use case: Articulating why customers should choose you over competitors — useful for your website, proposals, and sales conversations.

The Prompt:

```
Help me write a clear, compelling positioning statement for my business.

Business name: [NAME]
What we do: [BRIEF DESCRIPTION]
Our target customer: [WHO YOU SERVE — be specific]
The main problem we solve: [THE PRIMARY PAIN POINT YOU ADDRESS]
How we solve it differently from competitors: [YOUR APPROACH / WHAT MAKES YOU
DIFFERENT]
What results do customers typically get: [OUTCOMES, WITH NUMBERS IF YOU HAVE
THEM]

Write:
1. A one-sentence positioning statement (for use in introductions and headers)
2. A short paragraph (3-4 sentences) for our website About or Services page
3. A 30-second verbal pitch I could use when someone asks "what do you do?"

Tone: Confident, clear, and benefit-focused. Not corporate. Australian
English.
```

Prompt 10: 90-Day Plan Summary

Use case: Turning a set of goals and priorities into a structured 90-day plan you can actually use.

The Prompt:

```
I need to create a practical 90-day plan for my business.

Business context: [BRIEF DESCRIPTION OF YOUR BUSINESS AND CURRENT SITUATION]

My three most important goals for the next 90 days are:
1. [GOAL 1]
2. [GOAL 2]
3. [GOAL 3]

Current constraints:
- Time available: [E.G., "10 hours per week for this work"]
- Budget: [E.G., "$500/month"]
- Team: [E.G., "just me, with one part-time assistant"]

Create a 90-day plan that:
- Breaks into three 30-day phases (Foundation / Build / Optimise)
- Lists the 3-5 most important actions for each month
- Is realistic given my constraints (don't overload it)
- Includes a success metric for each goal
- Highlights any critical dependencies or risks

Format it as a clear, easy-to-follow document I can share with my team.
```

> **Tip: Saving Your Best Prompts** When you find a prompt that works really well for your business, save it somewhere accessible — a Google Doc, a Notion page, or even a simple Notes file. Build your own prompt library over time. The prompts you develop and refine yourself, tailored to your specific business and voice, will be among your most valuable AI assets.

SECTION 10

Next Steps + Your Free Ignition Audit

You've made it through the whole playbook. That already puts you in the top tier of business owners taking AI seriously.

Here's what to do next.

Your Immediate Next Steps (Do These Today)

Step 1: Calculate your score If you haven't done the self-assessment in Section 2 yet, go back and do it now. Don't skip it. Your score shapes everything else — the roadmap you follow, the tools you prioritise, the help you seek.

Step 2: Identify your lowest dimension Look at your five dimension scores. The lowest one is your biggest bottleneck. Even if your total score is reasonable, a single very low dimension can hold back your entire AI implementation. Start there.

Step 3: Choose one thing from your roadmap to do this week Not ten things. One thing. Looking at your 90-day roadmap (Section 6), what's the first action for Week 1? Do that. Not next month. This week.

Step 4: Try one prompt from the library Open ChatGPT or Claude right now (both have free versions at chat.openai.com and claude.ai). Pick the prompt from Section 9 most relevant to your current work. Spend 15 minutes with it. You'll walk away with something useful and a better instinct for how these tools work.

What to Do in the Next 30 Days

- Complete Month 1 of your readiness roadmap
- Have the conversation with your team about AI (Section 6 has guidance on this)
- Set your measurement baseline for the use case you're going to work on first
- If you're at Level 3 or 4, start your tool research based on the budget tier that fits (Section 7)

When You're Ready for More Support

This playbook gives you the framework, the assessment, and the roadmap. What it can't do is sit with you in your business, understand your specific industry dynamics, and build solutions tailored to your exact situation.

That's what we do.

About Ignition Agency

Ignition Agency helps Australian SMBs implement AI in ways that actually work — not flashy demos, not overpromised outcomes, but practical implementations that deliver measurable time savings, cost reductions, and revenue impact.

We work with businesses that are serious about getting this right. That means starting with your problem, not our favourite tool. Building things your team can understand and own. And measuring everything.

Our clients are typically: - Business owners with 5–50 staff - Revenue between $500K and $10M - Across professional services, trades, retail, health, and consulting - Ready to invest in proper implementation rather than endless experimentation

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Your Free 30-Minute AI Readiness Audit

We offer a free, no-obligation 30-minute audit for business owners who've completed this playbook.

In 30 minutes, we'll:

1. **Review your AI Readiness Score** — and discuss what the specific numbers mean for your business and industry
2. **Identify your highest-value opportunity** — the one use case most likely to deliver meaningful ROI in your specific context
3. **Give you a clear first step** — not a vague recommendation, but a specific, actionable next move

There's no sales pressure and no obligation. If we can help, we'll explain how. If we can't, or if you're better served by a different resource, we'll tell you that too.

Book Your Audit

Website: ignitionagency.au

To book your free 30-minute audit: Visit ignitionagency.au/audit

General enquiries: hello@ignitionagency.au

> **"The best time to prepare your business for AI was two years ago. The second best time is right now — but only if you do it properly."**
> — Ignition Agency

A Final Word

The businesses that will gain the most from AI over the next five years won't necessarily be the ones that adopted it earliest. They'll be the ones that adopted it

thoughtfully — with a clear problem to solve, a solid foundation underneath them, and the patience to iterate their way to something that genuinely works.

You've taken the first step by reading this playbook. The businesses that stay in the "curious but paralysed" zone are your competition. You've already separated yourself from them.

Now do the work.

We're here if you need us.

— The Ignition Agency Team ignitionagency.au

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END OF PLAYBOOK